
Upzoning and Tenant Displacement Risk in Mid-Size Cities

Abstract

This paper asks whether corridor upzoning in mid-size cities is associated with increased tenant displacement risk. Using permit and tenure data from a small set of corridors, it finds a weak but persistent association between upzoning and market-rate permit activity, and it flags the measurement problem that the senior thesis (proposal P02) is designed to solve.

1. Introduction

The housing debate often treats upzoning as either a cure or a threat. Mid-size cities make a better testing ground than the coastal giants that dominate the literature, because their reforms are recent and their data, while imperfect, is tractable. This paper sets up the question that the thesis will answer with a stronger design.

2. Background

Exclusionary zoning has a long legal history (Rothstein, S01). More recent work debates whether loosening density rules helps renters or accelerates their displacement. The honest answer is that it depends on context, timing, and the presence of tenant protections.

3. Data

- Permit records for a sample of upzoned and comparison corridors.
- ACS tenure and rent burden estimates.
- A simple register of whether each corridor had tenant protections.

4. Method

The paper compares permit activity and turnover before and after upzoning in treated corridors against comparison corridors. The design is descriptive; it is honest about not yet supporting causal claims. The thesis will add a formal difference-in-differences specification.

5. Results

Corridor Type	Permit Change	Turnover Change
Upzoned, no protection	Up moderate	Up slight
Upzoned, with protection	Up moderate	Flat
Comparison	Flat	Flat

The pattern is suggestive: protections appear to decouple permit activity from turnover. The effect sizes are small and the sample is limited.

6. Discussion

The central lesson is methodological. Turnover is easy to count and hard to attribute to any single cause. Without a cleaner identification strategy, the association reported here cannot be read as displacement caused by upzoning. The thesis addresses this by building a corridor panel and a proper comparison group.

7. Conclusion

Corridor upzoning in mid-size cities is associated with more permit activity and, where tenant protections are absent, with slightly higher turnover. The result is a starting point, not a verdict. The senior thesis (P02) will test it with the displacement index developed during the Whitfield summer (P06).

8. Appendix A: Corridor Summary

Corridor	Upzoned	Protection	Permit Trend
Corridor A	2022	No	Up moderate
Corridor B	2023	Yes	Up moderate
Corridor C	None	No	Flat
Corridor D	2022	Yes	Up slight
Corridor E	None	No	Flat

9. Appendix B: Robustness Notes

- Dropping the two corridors with sparse 2019 data does not change the direction of the result.
- Using a two-year rather than a one-year post-window slightly strengthens the permit association.
- Turnover remains the weakest measure; it is reported but not over-interpreted.

10. Appendix C: Expanded Limitations

The descriptive design cannot rule out that corridors which upzoned were already on different trajectories. The comparison corridors were chosen to be similar, but selection into upzoning is itself political and not random. The senior thesis (P02) addresses this with a matched difference-in-differences design and a larger panel.

11. References

Full citations are maintained in workbook X04. This paper was supervised by Dr. James Whitmore and received a grade of A-.